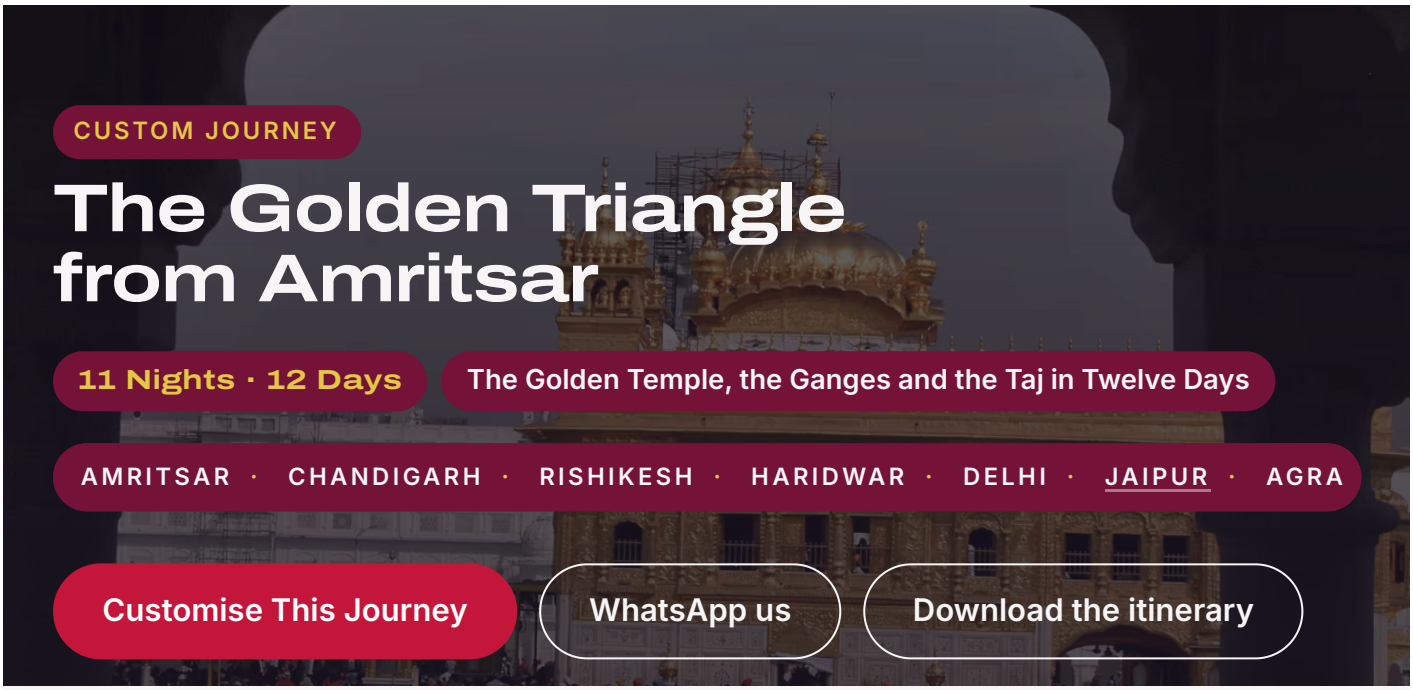
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DURATION
11 Nights · 12 Days

ROUTE
Amritsar → Delhi

PACE
Moderate

BEST SEASON
October to March

IDEAL FOR
First-Timers, Couples, Families

Most Golden Triangle journeys begin in Delhi. This one begins four hundred kilometres further north-west, at the Golden Temple in Amritsar, and takes the long way round: Le Corbusier's planned capital at Chandigarh, the Ganges where it leaves the hills at Rishikesh and Haridwar, and only then the capital, the pink city and the Taj. It is a route through the Sikh, Hindu and Mughal north in the order the country lays them out.

Twelve days is what that needs. The drives are broken by stepwells, border ceremonies and river ghats rather than endured, and the three cities of the triangle get the two nights each that let you see them at the right hour: the Taj in the morning, Amer before the heat, the Jama Masjid when the courtyard is quiet. Every transfer, guide and reservation is handled.

Journey Highlights

- **Begin** at the Golden Temple, the holiest of Sikh shrines, its gilded dome standing in the pool of nectar the city is named for.
- **Watch** the closing of the border at Wagah, a ceremony of marching, flag-lowering and theatre performed by the soldiers of two countries every evening.
- **Cross** from Chandigarh, the first planned city of independent India, to Rishikesh, where the Ganges leaves the mountains.
- **Stand** at Har ki Pauri in Haridwar and on the Lakshman Jhula for the evening Ganga aarti: lamps, chanting and the river carrying it all away.
- **Walk** Old and New Delhi in a day, from the Jama Masjid and Chandni Chowk to Qutub Minar and Humayun's Tomb.
- **Climb** to Amer Fort above Jaipur, then into the pink city's palaces, its stone observatory and its bazaars.
- **Descend** the thirteen storeys of Chand Baori, the deepest stepwell in India, on the road to Agra and the Taj Mahal.

Itinerary at a Glance

DAY	DESTINATION	SIGNATURE EXPERIENCE
Day 01	**Amritsar**	Arrival in the city of the Golden Temple
Day 02	**Amritsar**	The Golden Temple, then the Wagah border ceremony
Day 03	**Amritsar to Chandigarh**	Le Corbusier's planned city: Secretariat, High Court, Rose Garden

DAY	DESTINATION	SIGNATURE EXPERIENCE
Day 04	**Chandigarh to Rishikesh**	To the Ganges where it leaves the hills
Day 05	**Rishikesh and Haridwar**	Har ki Pauri, the Lakshman Jhula and the evening aarti
Day 06	**Rishikesh to Delhi**	The road to the capital
Day 07	**Delhi**	Old and New Delhi in a day
Day 08	**Delhi to Jaipur**	Into Rajasthan
Day 09	**Jaipur**	Amer Fort, City Palace, Jantar Mantar and the markets
Day 10	**Jaipur to Agra**	The Chand Baori stepwell at Abhaneri en route
Day 11	**Agra**	The Taj Mahal and Agra Fort
Day 12	**Agra to Delhi**	Return to Delhi for the onward flight

Day by Day

Expand all

Day 01 Amritsar: The Pool of Nectar

Met on arrival at Amritsar and taken to your hotel. The city takes its name from the Amrit Sarovar, the pool of nectar that surrounds the Golden Temple; it was Ram Das Pura before that, and a gathering place for saints and sages long before Guru Nanak's teachings gave it its present purpose. The rest of the day is free to settle in and find your way to the old city's lanes.

Overnight in Amritsar

Day 02 Amritsar: The Golden Temple and the Wagah Border

The morning at the Harmandir Sahib, the Golden Temple, the holiest shrine of the Sikhs: a gilded dome in the middle of the sacred tank, four entrances to say that anyone of any faith is welcome, and the Guru Granth Sahib at its centre. The community kitchen feeds tens of thousands a day and you are welcome to eat there. In the evening, the drive out to the Wagah border for the closing ceremony: the soldiers of India and Pakistan marching, the flags lowered and folded in unison, and a crowd that treats it as the theatre it is.

Overnight in Amritsar

Day 03 Chandigarh: The Planned City

Drive · about 230 km

South-east to Chandigarh, the first planned city of independent India, laid out when Punjab needed a new capital after Partition and designed by Le Corbusier with Pierre Jeanneret, Jane Drew and Maxwell Fry. The name means the fort of Chandi, after a temple nearby. After check-in, a tour of the Capitol Complex (the Secretariat, the High Court with its great coloured piers) and the Rose Garden, with tens of thousands of bushes across some sixteen hundred varieties, then the Botanical Gardens.

Overnight in Chandigarh

Day 04 Rishikesh: Where the Ganges Leaves the Hills

Drive · about 200 km

Across the plains and up to Rishikesh, in the foothills where the Ganges comes down out of the mountains. It is one of the holiest cities in India and one of the calmest: ashrams, yoga schools, suspension bridges, and the river itself moving fast and cold and green. The Beatles came here in 1968 to the Maharishi's ashram and wrote most of an album. Check in to your hotel, with the evening free by the water.

Overnight in Rishikesh

Day 05 Haridwar and Rishikesh: The Evening Aarti

In the morning, the short drive to Haridwar, the gateway to God, where the Ganges enters the plains and where, in Hindu belief, a drop of the nectar of immortality fell during the churning of the ocean. Har ki Pauri, the steps of God, is the ghat that marks the spot, and the Kumbh Mela gathers here in its turn. Back in Rishikesh, cross the Lakshman Jhula suspension bridge and walk the temples, and at dusk take a place on the ghat for the Ganga aarti: lamps, bells, chanting, and the river carrying the little leaf-boats of flame away into the dark.

Overnight in Rishikesh

Day 06 Delhi: The Road to the Capital

Drive · about 240 km

Down to Delhi, the city of cities, destroyed and rebuilt so many times that its history is a matter of layers rather than dates. Met at your hotel by our representative, with the rest of the day free. The Mughal food of the old city is a reasonable first evening.

Overnight in Delhi

Day 07 Delhi: Two Cities in One Day

Old Delhi first: Shah Jahan's walled city of 1639, Raj Ghat where Gandhi was cremated and the museum beside it, a drive past the Red Fort, and the Jama Masjid, whose courtyard holds twenty-five thousand. A rickshaw through Chandni Chowk if you would like one. The market is best at handlebar height. Then New Delhi: Qutub Minar, the tallest minaret in India and a UNESCO site since 1192's builders could not have imagined; Humayun's Tomb, commissioned by his widow in 1569; India Gate; a drive past Parliament and the presidential estate; and the Lakshminarayan Temple to finish.

Overnight in Delhi

Day 08 Jaipur: Into Rajasthan

Drive · about 270 km

South-west to Jaipur, the pink city and the city of palaces: the Hawa Mahal with its nine hundred windows, the royal residences still lived in, and markets that give you the life of the place as much as its architecture. Check in, and take the afternoon as you find it: a rest, or a first walk through the bazaars.

Explore Jaipur →

Overnight in Jaipur

Day 09 Jaipur: Amer, Mirrors and an Observatory

Amer Fort first, in the hills above the city, with the climb to the gate by jeep. Raja Man Singh built it in red sandstone and marble around four courtyards, and inside are the Suraj Pol gate, the Sila Devi temple by the Ganesh Gate, the halls of public and private audience, the Sheesh Mahal lined with mirrors, and the Sukh Niwas, cooled by wind drawn across falling water. In the city, the seven-storey City Palace in its Rajput, Mughal and European blend, and the stone instruments of the Jantar Mantar observatory, which still draw astronomers. The afternoon is for the main markets: footwear, carpets, handmade jewellery.

Explore Jaipur →

Overnight in Jaipur

Day 10 Abhaneri: The Stepwell on the Road to Agra

Drive · about 240 km, with the stop at Abhaneri

East towards Agra, breaking the journey at the village of Abhaneri, once Abha Nagri, the city of brightness. It is famous for its baoris, the stepwells the region built to harvest rain and to keep cool, and the greatest of them is Chand Baori, the largest and deepest in India, its thirteen storeys of steps descending in front of the Harshat Mata Temple, where hands were washed before worship. On to Agra, with the evening free.

Overnight in Agra

Day 11 Agra: The Taj and the Fort

The Taj Mahal in the morning, on the bank of the Yamuna: white marble, built by Shah Jahan for Mumtaz Mahal between 1631 and 1648, and one of the few celebrated buildings that is larger in person than in the photographs. It is closed on Fridays. Then Agra Fort, the earlier sandstone twin of Delhi's Red Fort and a UNESCO site, with its gardens, the Khas Mahal and Jahangir Palace, and the two audience halls. Agra is also the city of marble inlay, and the afternoon is free for its workshops.

Overnight in Agra

Day 12 Agra to Delhi: Departure

Drive · about 230 km to Delhi airport

The road back to Delhi in good time for your homebound flight. No accommodation is reserved for this day; if your flight is early the next morning we will arrange a day room rather than have you wait in a terminal.

Departure

Practical notes

Getting there

Arrive at Amritsar (ATQ), which has direct flights from Delhi and a growing set of international connections; depart from Delhi (DEL).

Best time to visit

October to March. Amritsar and the plains are cold in December and January, which suits the temple and the border ceremony well, and the Golden Triangle is at its most comfortable.

Ideal duration

Twelve days is what the route needs. It crosses four states and two rivers before it reaches the Golden Triangle at all. Add a

Pace

Moderate. Four driving days of roughly four to five hours, each of them broken by something worth stopping for, with

night in Rishikesh if you would like a full day of doing nothing by the river.	monument mornings and free afternoons between.